

NFL Draft Innovation Challenge 2026: NOVATE Managed Service Architecture v1

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Executive Summary

This document specifies the complete architecture for the NFL Draft Innovation Challenge 2026 as a **fully managed service delivered by NOVATE Inc**, eliminating NFL infrastructure dependencies while maintaining security, sovereignty, and strategic control. NOVATE operates all systems end-to-end using the Sentrais Intelligence Engine, EVERGAME temporal orchestration framework, and N-Ovate Innovation Nexus (NIN) methodology.

Key Architecture Shifts

Previous Model (v1.0)	New Model (v2.0) - Managed Service
Dual infrastructure (Pitchtape + Sentrais in NFL VPC)	Single NOVATE-hosted infrastructure with Pitchtape integration
NFL AWS VPC ownership	NOVATE AWS infrastructure with secure client portal access
Webhook-based data sync	Real-time orchestration through Sentrais Intelligence Engine
Manual vendor evaluation	AI-powered vendor scoring via Sentrais + NIN methodology
Stage gates managed by NFL	NOVATE orchestrates all gates with NFL approval checkpoints

Value Proposition for NFL

What NFL Gains:

- **Expert Orchestration:** NOVATE operates using proven Innovation Orchestration Framework

- **Strategic Intelligence:** Real-time Sentrais dashboard with predictive analytics and vendor risk scoring
- **Vendor Neutrality:** NOVATE provides independent, forensic evaluation preventing vendor capture
- **Scalability:** Framework extends to future Innovation Challenges (2027, 2028+) and other HUB programs

What NFL Retains:

- **Strategic Control:** Approval authority at all stage gates
 - **Data Sovereignty:** Complete ownership of all submission data, evaluations, and outcomes
 - **Vendor Relationships:** Direct NFL-vendor contracts; NOVATE facilitates but doesn't own relationships
 - **Brand Ownership:** NFL Innovation HUB brand, communications, and vendor-facing presence
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Section 1: Service Delivery Model

1.1 NOVATE Responsibilities

Complete Service Ownership:

1. Platform Operations

- Host and operate Sentrais Intelligence Engine in NOVATE GCP infrastructure
- Integrate Pitchtape as vendor-facing intake portal (NOVATE pays license, NFL white-labeled)
- Configure and maintain NFL360 data model for all innovation submissions
- Deploy EVERGAME temporal orchestration for multi-stage workflow management
- Provide 24/7 platform monitoring, security, and incident response

2. Innovation Orchestration

- Execute NIN 6-phase methodology (Discovery → Blueprinting → Co-Design → Pilot → Operationalization → Measurement)
- Conduct vendor due diligence using forensic evaluation frameworks
- Coordinate POC testing, demo scheduling, and technical validation
- Generate Evidence Ledger with immutable audit trail of all decisions
- Produce Sentrais Intelligence Reports (weekly snapshots, stage gate summaries, final recommendations)

3. Vendor Coordination

- Manage all vendor communications (onboarding, Q&A, status updates, rejections)
- Schedule and facilitate demos, technical evaluations, and security reviews
- Coordinate POC deployments (if applicable) including sandbox environment setup
- Maintain vendor scorecard and comparative analytics across submissions

4. NFL Stakeholder Support

- Configure role-based access for NFL reviewers (IT, Operations, Media, Sponsorship leads)
- Conduct weekly status sync meetings with NFL
- Present stage gate recommendations to Executive Steering Committee
- Provide training and support for NFL360 Dashboard usage
- Deliver post-Challenge debrief and lessons learned

1.2 NFL Responsibilities

Strategic Oversight Only:

1. Program Direction

- Define innovation priority areas (OnePass integration, fan experience, broadcast tech, etc.)
- Approve stage gate advancement (Stage 1 → 2, Stage 2 → 3, Stage 3 → 4)
- Select final Draft Day winners from NOVATE's certified shortlist
- Make final vendor contract decisions (NOVATE provides recommendations only)

2. Stakeholder Access

- Designate reviewer accounts (up to 10 NFL stakeholders)
- Provide subject matter expert availability for technical evaluations (IT, security, compliance)
- Participate in stage gate review meetings (bi-weekly cadence)

3. Branding & Communications

- Own external communications to potential vendors (challenge announcements, promotional materials)
 - Approve email templates and vendor-facing messaging (NOVATE drafts, NFL approves)
 - Host Draft Day announcement event (NOVATE provides finalist briefing materials)
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Section 2: Sentrais Intelligence Engine Architecture

2.1 Sentrais Core Components

Sentrais serves as the unified orchestration platform integrating:

- 1. **NFL360 Data Model:** Unified schema for vendor submissions, evaluations, and outcomes
- 2. **EVERGAME Temporal Engine:** Multi-stage workflow orchestration with time-bound phase transitions
- 3. **Evidence Ledger:** Immutable audit trail (blockchain-secured) of all decisions and scoring
- 4. **NIN Methodology Mapper:** Maps all activities to the 6-phase innovation lifecycle
- 5. **Intelligence Dashboard:** Real-time visualization for NFL stakeholders

2.2 Sentrais Deployment Architecture

Hosting: NOVATE AWS Account (us-east-1) (GCP)

- **Infrastructure:** Kubernetes cluster (EKS) with auto-scaling
- **Database:** PostgreSQL 14 + TimescaleDB (time-series data for temporal orchestration)
- **Storage:** S3 for videos, pitch decks, technical documentation
- **Compute:** Lambda functions for event-driven workflows (e.g., vendor scoring, notification triggers)
- **Security:** SOC2 Type II compliant infrastructure, AWS KMS encryption, MFA enforcement

NFL Access Model:

- **NFL360 Dashboard URL:** <https://nfl-draft-2026.novatelabs.com> (white-labeled, NFL Innovation HUB branding)
- **Authentication:** Azure AD SSO integration (NFL's existing identity provider)
- **Network:** Public HTTPS access (no VPN required), with IP whitelisting for NFL corporate network
- **Data Export:** NFL can request full data export (JSON/CSV) at any time; final export provided automatically at Challenge conclusion

2.3 Pitchtape Integration

Pitchtape Role: Vendor-facing intake portal only

Function	Tool	Notes

Vendor Submission Form	Pitchtape	6-step wizard (Innovation Profile, Video, Deck, OnePass, Team, Review)
Vendor Dashboard	Pitchtape	Status tracking (Stage 1-4 visibility)
Real-time Data Sync	Sentrais	Pitchtape webhooks → Sentrais ingestion API (no NFL VPC)
Reviewer Workspace	Sentrais NFL360 Dashboard	NFL stakeholders never log into Pitchtape
Orchestration Logic	Sentrais	All stage gates, scoring, and decision workflows
Evidence Ledger	Sentrais	Immutable audit trail
Reporting	Sentrais	Intelligence reports, vendor comparisons

Why Keep Pitchtape?

- **Proven UI:** Pitchtape's submission wizard and video recording tools are best-in-class for vendor experience
- **No Development Cost:** Avoid building redundant intake forms; focus NOVATE engineering on orchestration intelligence
- **Vendor Familiarity:** Many vendors have used Pitchtape for other challenges (NFL, NBA, MLS)
- **Migration Path:** NOVATE can deprecate Pitchtape in 2027 if custom intake is desired (captured in Section 8)

Section 3: EVERGAME Temporal Orchestration Framework

3.1 EVERGAME Overview

EVERGAME is NOVATE's temporal orchestration engine that maps real-world events (vendor submissions, reviewer evaluations, stage gates) to structured time-series workflows. It ensures:

- **Temporal Accountability:** Every action is timestamped and sequenced
- **Dependency Management:** Stage 2 cannot begin until Stage 1 completion criteria are met
- **Predictive Analytics:** AI models forecast bottlenecks (e.g., "3 reviewers haven't evaluated 12 submissions; Stage 2 deadline at risk")

- **Evidence Chain:** Immutable ledger links decisions to temporal context (e.g., "Decision made on Jan 28, 2026 based on data available as of Jan 25, 2026")

3.2 Four-Stage Temporal Mapping

The NFL Draft Challenge maps to **EVERGAME's Event-Phase-Gate-Outcome** model:

None

EVENT (Submission) → PHASE (Review) → GATE (Advancement Decision)
→ OUTCOME (Certified/Declined)

Stage 1: Discovery (Scouting)

Temporal Window: Jan 15 - Feb 15, 2026 (30 days)

NIN Phase	EVERGAME Phase	Activity	Completion Criteria
P1: Discovery	Discovery (Scouting)	Vendor submissions intake via Pitchtape	All submissions received by Feb 15
P2: Blueprinting	Forensic Evaluation	Reviewer evaluations (IT, Ops, Media, Sponsorship leads)	All assigned reviewers submit scores + comments

Stage Gate 1 Logic:

- **Sentrais Composite Score $\geq 70\%$** → Advance to Stage 2 (Validation)
- **Sentrais Composite Score $< 70\%$** → Decline (automated email via Pitchtape)
- **Manual Override:** NFL can override Sentrais recommendation (logged in Evidence Ledger with justification)

EVERGAME Temporal Rules:

- Reviewers have **7 days** from assignment to submit evaluation
- If reviewer non-responsive after 5 days → Escalation to Tracy Rodberg
- If deadline approaches with $<80\%$ evaluations complete → NOVATE Project Manager alerts NFL stakeholders

Stage 2: Validation (Combine)

Temporal Window: Feb 16 - Mar 31, 2026 (45 days)

NIN Phase	EVERGAME Phase	Activity	Completion Criteria
P3: Co-Design & Innovation	POC Testing (Vendor-Neutral Harness)	Vendors demonstrate solutions in controlled NFL scenarios	Technical validation complete
P4: Pilot & Testing	Integration Feasibility Analysis	NOVATE assesses OnePass API compatibility, security compliance	Technical scorecard finalized

Stage Gate 2 Logic:

- **Technical Validation Score $\geq 75\%$ + Security Compliance = Pass** → Advance to Stage 3
- **NFL Stakeholder Vote:** IT Lead (Aaron Amendola) must approve technical readiness

EVERGAME Temporal Rules:

- Each vendor allocated **2-hour demo slot** (scheduled by NOVATE within 10 days of Stage 2 entry)
- Technical Q&A responses due within **48 hours** of demo
- Security compliance review (SOC2, data handling) completed within **14 days**

Stage 3: Evaluation (War Room)

Temporal Window: Apr 1 - Apr 20, 2026 (20 days)

NIN Phase	EVERGAME Phase	Activity	Completion Criteria
P5: Operationalization	Business Case Development	NOVATE generates ROI models, deployment roadmaps, risk assessments	Executive briefing materials complete
P2: Blueprinting (Deep Dive)	Comparative Benchmarking	Side-by-side vendor comparison (features, pricing, implementation timeline)	Final shortlist (3-5 vendors)

Stage Gate 3 Logic:

- **NFL Executive Steering Committee** reviews NOVATE's recommendations
- **Shortlist Finalized:** 3-5 vendors selected for Draft Day presentation

EVERGAME Temporal Rules:

- NOVATE delivers **Executive Briefing Deck** 5 days before Stage Gate 3 meeting
- NFL stakeholders have **3 days** to provide feedback before final shortlist lock

Stage 4: Selection (Draft Day)

Temporal Window: Apr 24-26, 2026 (NFL Draft Week)

NIN Phase	EVERGAME Phase	Activity	Completion Criteria
P6: Measurement & Iteration	Draft Day Presentation	Finalists present to NFL leadership (Commissioner's office, EVPs)	Winners announced
P6: Measurement & Iteration	Post-Challenge Debrief	NOVATE delivers lessons learned, Evidence Ledger, vendor ecosystem report	Knowledge base updated for 2027

Stage Gate 4 Logic:

- **NFL Leadership Decision:** Commissioner or designee selects winner(s)
- **NOVATE Role:** Provides finalist briefing materials, moderates presentations (optional), captures outcomes in Evidence Ledger

Section 4: NIN Methodology Integration

4.1 NIN 6-Phase Lifecycle Mapping

The **N-Ovate Innovation Nexus (NIN)** methodology is NOVATE's proprietary framework for forensic innovation management. Every NFL Draft Challenge activity maps to one of six NIN phases:

NIN Phase	Challenge Activity	Deliverable	Evidence Ledger Entry
P1: Discovery	Vendor submissions intake	Pitchtape submissions database	"Submission #2026-0042 received: TGI Virtual Signage"

P2: Blueprinting	Forensic evaluation (reviewers score submissions)	Reviewer scorecards, composite scores	"Reviewer Aaron Amendola scored TGI 4/5 on Technical Readiness"
P3: Co-Design & Innovation	POC testing, vendor demos	Demo recordings, technical Q&A logs	"TGI demo completed; OnePass API integration validated"
P4: Pilot & Testing	Security compliance, integration feasibility	Security audit reports, API test results	"TGI SOC2 Type II verified; API latency <200ms"
P5: Operationalization	Business case development, ROI modeling	Executive briefing decks, deployment roadmaps	"TGI ROI model: \$2.4M savings over 3 years"
P6: Measurement & Iteration	Draft Day selection, post-challenge debrief	Final recommendations, lessons learned	"Winner: TGI Virtual Signage; Runner-up: ASCEND"

4.2 Forensic Rigor Requirements

Forensic Innovation Principle: Every decision must be evidence-backed, timestamped, and auditable.

NOVATE's Forensic Standards for NFL Challenge:

1. No Subjective Decisions Without Evidence

- Reviewers cannot advance a vendor without documented scores and comments
- Sentra's flags evaluations lacking supporting rationale

2. Transparent Vendor Comparison

- All vendors evaluated against the same criteria (no moving goalposts)
- Comparative scorecards published in NFL360 Dashboard

3. Immutable Evidence Chain

- Evidence Ledger uses blockchain-style merkle tree for tamper-proof audit trail
- Every stage gate decision includes: timestamp, decision-maker, rationale, supporting data

4. Independent Validation

- NOVATE provides third-party technical validation (not reliant on vendor claims)

- Vendor-Neutral Harness (simulated OnePass environment) tests integration without vendor involvement

Section 5: NFL360 Dashboard (Sentrais Frontend)

5.1 Dashboard Access Roles

Role	NFL Stakeholders	Access Level	Key Functions
Executive Sponsor	Gsry Brantley (SVP Innovation)	Full visibility, read-only on evaluations, approval authority at Stage Gates	View all submissions, composite scores, stage gate recommendations; approve/reject advancements
Program Lead	(Knox Phillips, Commercial Lead)	Full visibility, read-only on evaluations	Monitor pipeline health, vendor communications, business case reviews
Technical Reviewer	Aaron Amendola (IT Lead) + 1	Evaluation write access (Technical criteria only)	Score vendors on Technical Readiness, OnePass Integration, Security; ask clarifying questions
Operations Reviewer	(2 stakeholders)	Evaluation write access (Operational criteria only)	Score vendors on Operational Feasibility, Deployment Complexity, Scalability
Media Reviewer	(2 stakeholders)	Evaluation write access (Media criteria only)	Score vendors on Broadcast Integration, Content Potential, Fan Experience
Sponsorship Reviewer	(Commercial)	Evaluation write access (Commercial criteria only)	Score vendors on Monetization Potential, Partner Fit, Revenue Model
NOVATE Admin	Tye Hayes, Tionna Taylor	Full platform administration	Configure workflows, generate reports, troubleshoot, export data

5.2 Dashboard Layout (Role: Executive Sponsor View)

URL: <https://nfl-draft-2026.novatelabs.com> (Azure AD SSO)

None

NFL DRAFT INNOVATION CHALLENGE 2026 - EXECUTIVE DASHBOARD

Logged in as: Gary Brantley (SVP Innovation)

Challenge Status: Stage 2 - Validation (Combine) | 23 days remaining

PIPELINE OVERVIEW

	Stage 1: Discovery (Scouting)	47 submissions → 18 advanced
	Stage 2: Validation (Combine)	18 in progress
	Stage 3: Evaluation (War Room)	0 (opens Apr 1)
	Stage 4: Selection (Draft Day)	0 (Apr 24-26)

STAGE 2 HEALTH METRICS

Demos Scheduled:	12 of 18 (67%)	
Demos Completed:	8 of 12 (67%)	
Technical Validations:	6 of 8 (75%)	2 vendors pending
Security Reviews:	4 of 8 (50%)	4 vendors overdue

⚠ Action Required: 4 vendors missing SOC2 documentation

NOVATE sent follow-up emails on Jan 20; responses due Jan 22

TOP PERFORMING VENDORS (Stage 2 Composite Score)

1. TGI Virtual Signage	89%	[View Profile]
2. ASCEND	87%	[View Profile]
3. Forty Sports Technology	84%	[View Profile]
4. Aucom	81%	[View Profile]
5. Genius Sports (Second Spectrum)	78%	[View Profile]

[\[View Full Vendor List\]](#)
[\[Stage Gate 2 Recommendation Report\]](#)

[\[Export Data \(CSV\)\]](#)
[\[Schedule Briefing with NOVATE\]](#)

5.3 Vendor Profile Page (Drill-Down from Dashboard)

Example: TGI Virtual Signage

None

VENDOR PROFILE: TGI Virtual Signage

Innovation: AI-Powered Broadcast Overlays & Virtual Signage

|

|

|

|

|

|

|

| COMPOSITE SCORE: 89% (Stage 2: Validation) 

STRONG |

|

|

| Stage 1 (Discovery): 4.2/5 (84%)  Advanced

|

| Stage 2 (Validation): 4.5/5 (89%)  In Progress

|

| Stage 3 (Evaluation): -  Pending

|

|

|

|

|

|

| REVIEWER SCORES (Stage 2)

|

|

|

| Technical Readiness (IT Lead): 5/5 

|

| "Excellent API design; REST integration with OnePass is

straightfor-|

| | ward. Security compliance verified (SOC2 Type II). Low latency." | |

| |

| | OnePass Integration (IT Lead): 5/5 ★★★★★

| |

| | "Demo showed seamless OAuth flow. Fan profile data mapping is clean." | |

| | No custom work needed for pilot deployment."

| |

| |

| | Broadcast Integration (Media Lead): 4/5 ★★★★★☆

| |

| | "Strong real-time rendering. Needs broadcaster workflow refinement." | |

| |

| | Monetization Potential (Commercial): 4/5 ★★★★★☆

| |

| | "Clear sponsorship integration model. Pricing competitive." | |

| |

| |

| |

| |

| |

| | TECHNICAL VALIDATION (NOVATE Independent Testing)

| |

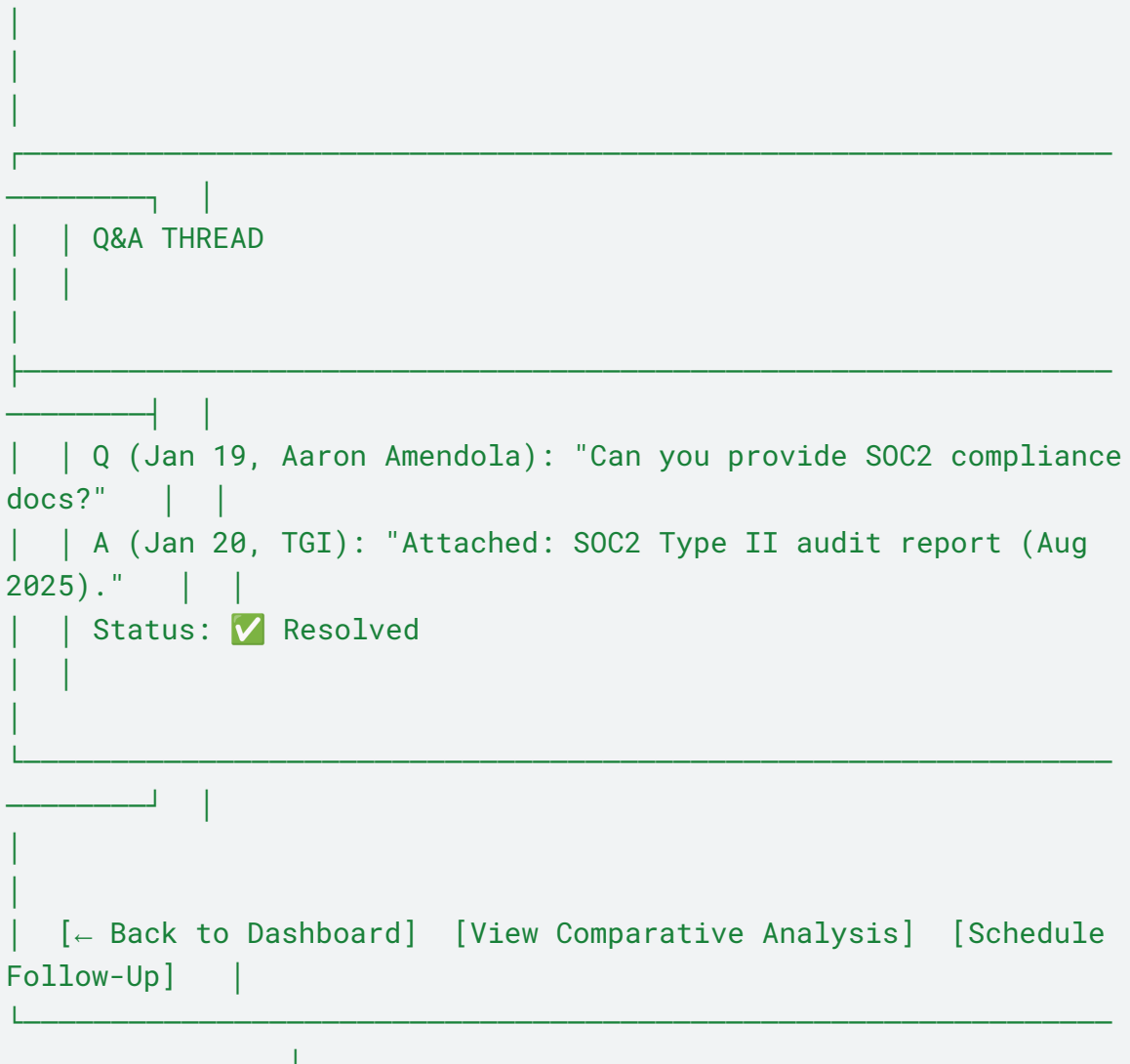
| |

| |

- ✓ API Latency: <150ms (Target: <200ms)
- ✓ Uptime (30-day): 99.97% (Target: 99.9%)
- ✓ Security Scan: 0 critical vulnerabilities
- ✓ Data Compliance: SOC2 Type II verified (Aug 2025)
- ⚠ Load Testing: Pending (scheduled Jan 25)

VENDOR ASSETS

- 🎥 Pitch Video (2:47) [Watch]
- 📄 Pitch Deck (12 slides) [View PDF]
- 📋 Technical Architecture Diagram [View PDF]
- 🎬 Demo Recording (Jan 18, 2026) [Watch]
- 📊 NOVATE Security Audit Report [Download]



Section 6: Vendor Workflow (Pitchtape → Sentrais Integration)

6.1 Vendor Journey Map

None

Vendor submits via Pitchtape



```

Sentrais ingests submission in real-time (webhook)
↓
NOVATE assigns reviewers (automatic, role-based)
↓
Reviewers score via NFL360 Dashboard (not Pitchtape)
↓
Sentrais calculates composite score (weighted algorithm)
↓
Stage Gate 1: Sentrais recommends Advance/Decline
↓
NFL approves recommendation (Gary Brantley)
↓
Sentrais pushes status update to Pitchtape (API call)
↓
Vendor sees updated status in Pitchtape dashboard
↓
NOVATE sends email notification (via Pitchtape API)

```

6.2 Data Flow: Pitchtape → Sentrais

Webhook Trigger: Vendor completes 6-step submission and clicks "Submit to NFL"

Pitchtape Webhook Payload:

```

JSON
{
  "event_type": "submission.completed",
  "timestamp": "2026-01-28T14:32:00Z",
  "pitchtape_submission_id": "PT-2026-0128",
  "initiative": {
    "id": "nfl-draft-challenge-2026",
    "name": "NFL Draft Innovation Challenge 2026"
  },
  "vendor": {
    "company_name": "TGI Virtual Signage",
    "contact_email": "contact@tgi.com",
  }
}

```

```

    "website": "https://tgi.com",
    "team_members": [...],
  },
  "innovation": {
    "name": "AI-Powered Virtual Signage",
    "category": "fan_journey_personalization",
    "video": {
      "url": "https://pitchtape-cdn.com/videos/PT-2026-0128.mp4",
      "transcript": "Hi, I'm Jane Doe from TGI..."
    },
    "pitch_deck": {
      "url":
"https://pitchtape-cdn.com/files/PT-2026-0128-deck.pdf"
    }
  },
  "onepass_integration": {
    "components": ["mobile_app", "web_platform",
"broadcast_media"],
    "integration_approach": "api_sdk"
  }
}

```

Sentrais Ingestion Endpoint: POST

<https://api.novatelabs.com/sentrais/nfl-draft-2026/submissions/ingest>

Sentrais Response:

JSON

```

{
  "innovation_id": "INNO-2026-0128",
  "orchestration_status": "discovery_submitted",
  "zone_placement": "incubation",
  "nin_phase": "P1_Discovery",
  "evergame_stage": "Stage1_Scouting",
  "assigned_reviewers": [

```

```

    "aaron.amendola@nfl.com",
    "tracy.rodberg@nfl.com",
    "brad.boim@nfl.com",
    "dan.commercial@nfl.com"
  ],
  "estimated_review_completion": "2026-02-05T00:00:00Z"
}
```

6.3 Reviewer Evaluation Workflow (Sentrais-Native)

NFL reviewers DO NOT log into Pitchtape. All evaluations occur in Sentrais NFL360 Dashboard.

Reviewer Assignment (Automatic):

- Sentrais analyzes submission category (e.g., "fan_journey_personalization")
- Assigns role-appropriate reviewers (IT, Operations, Media, Sponsorship)
- Sends email notification: "New submission ready for your review"

Reviewer Evaluation Interface (Sentrais):

[illegible]

(2:47)	
	Solution: AI-powered fan
[▶ Play]	personalization engine that analyzes
	behavior across NFL digital properties.
[View Transcript]	
	OnePass Integration: REST API
	connecting to fan profile system.
 DECK	Team: 3 founders (ex-Google, ex-Meta),
(12 slides)	Series A stage.
[View PDF]	
	Key Strengths: Strong ML/AI expertise,
	proven personalization in sports.
	Potential Concerns: Unproven at NFL
	scale, security compliance TBD.

YOUR EVALUATION (IT LEAD PERSPECTIVE)

Technical Readiness (40% weight) ★★★★★☆ 4/5

Comments: [Strong API design, needs security review]

OnePass Integration (30% weight) ★★★★★☆ 4/5

Comments: [Clear integration path, standard REST]

Security & Compliance (20% weight) ★★★★★☆ 3/5

Comments: [SOC2 docs pending, needs follow-up]

Data Architecture (10% weight) ★★★★★★ 5/5

Comments: [Well-designed data model]

Confidence Level: ☐ Low ☒ Medium ☐ High

```
| | Open Questions for Vendor:
| |
| | [Can you provide SOC2 compliance documentation?]
| |
| |
| |
| | [Save Draft] [Submit Review]
| |
| |
| |
| |
| |
```

Data Flow: Reviewer Evaluation → Sentrais → Pitchtape

1. **Reviewer submits evaluation** in Sentrais NFL360 Dashboard
2. **Sentrais stores evaluation** in NFL360 data model (PostgreSQL)
3. **Sentrais logs Evidence Ledger entry**: "Aaron Amendola scored TGI 4/5 on Technical Readiness (Jan 19, 2026 10:23:47 UTC)"
4. **Sentrais checks stage gate logic**: Have all reviewers evaluated this submission?
 - If **YES** → Calculate composite score → Trigger Stage Gate 1 workflow
 - If **NO** → Send reminder email to pending reviewers (if deadline < 2 days)

6.4 Stage Gate Decision Workflow

Stage Gate 1 Example: Discovery → Validation

Trigger: All assigned reviewers have submitted evaluations for a submission

Sentrais Composite Score Calculation:

None

Composite Score = Weighted Average of All Reviewer Scores

Example (TGI Virtual Signage):

- IT Lead (Technical): 4/5 → 80% (weight: 40%) = 32%
- IT Lead (OnePass): 4/5 → 80% (weight: 30%) = 24%

- IT Lead (Security): 3/5 → 60% (weight: 20%) = 12%
- IT Lead (Data Arch): 5/5 → 100% (weight: 10%) = 10%

Composite Score = 32% + 24% + 12% + 10% = 78% ADVANCE
(threshold: 70%)

Sentrais Recommendation Engine:

- **Score $\geq 70\%$ → Recommendation: **ADVANCE** to Stage 2**
- **Score $< 70\%$ → Recommendation: **DECLINE** (do not advance)**

NFL Approval Checkpoint: Sentrais generates **Stage Gate 1 Recommendation Report** and sends to Tracy Rodberg:

None

STAGE GATE 1 RECOMMENDATION REPORT

Discovery (Scouting) → Validation (Combine)

Generated by: NOVATE Sentrais Intelligence Engine

Date: February 5, 2026

Reviewed Submissions: 47

RECOMMENDATION: ADVANCE 18 VENDORS TO STAGE 2

Top 5 Vendors (Composite Score ≥ 80%):

1. TGI Virtual Signage

89%

2. ASCEND

87%

3. Forty Sports Technology

84%

4. Aucom

81%

5. Genius Sports

80%

Additional 13 vendors (70-79% range): [View List]

Declined 29 vendors (<70%): [View List]

[Approve Recommendation] [Request Changes] [Schedule Review Call]

Tracy's Options:

1. **Approve Recommendation** → Sentrais advances 18 vendors to Stage 2, declines 29 vendors (automated emails sent via Pitchtape)
2. **Request Changes** → Tracy specifies exceptions (e.g., "Manually advance Vendor XYZ despite 68% score due to strategic fit")
3. **Schedule Review Call** → NOVATE schedules 30-minute call to discuss borderline cases

Evidence Ledger Entry:

None

```
{
  "timestamp": "2026-02-05T14:30:00Z",
  "event": "stage_gate_1_decision",
  "decision_maker": "tracy.rodberg@nfl.com",
  "decision": "approved_sentrais_recommendation",
  "vendors_advanced": 18,
  "vendors_declined": 29,
  "manual_overrides": 0,
  "rationale": "Sentrais composite scores aligned with NFL strategic priorities"
}
```

6.5 Vendor Notification (Sentrais → Pitchtape API)

Scenario: TGI Virtual Signage advances to Stage 2

Sentrais API Call to Pitchtape:

None

PATCH

<https://api.pitchtape.com/v1/submissions/PT-2026-0128/status>

Authorization: Bearer {PITCHTAPE_API_KEY}

Content-Type: application/json

```
{
  "sentrais_innovation_id": "INNO-2026-0128",
  "orchestration_status": "validation_in_progress",
}
```

```
"stage": 2,  
"stage_name": "Validation (Combine)",  
"applicant_visible_message": "Congratulations! Your innovation  
has advanced to Stage 2: Validation. You'll receive a demo  
scheduling email within 48 hours.",  
"updated_at": "2026-02-05T14:35:00Z"  
}
```

Pitchtape Triggers Email Notification (Using Pitchtape's Email Template):

None

Subject: 🏈 You've Advanced to Stage 2: Validation (Combine)

Hi Jane,

Congratulations! Your innovation, AI-Powered Virtual Signage, has successfully completed Stage 1: Discovery (Scouting) and advanced to Stage 2: Validation (Combine).

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Stage 2: Validation (Combine)
You'll participate in NFL-controlled proof-of-concept (POC) testing to validate your solution's capabilities against real-world scenarios.

Next Steps:

1. Schedule Your Demo (within 48 hours)
[Schedule Demo →]

2. Review Demo Preparation Guide

[[View Guide →](#)]

3. Prepare for Technical Q&A

NFL stakeholders (IT, Operations, Media, Sponsorship) will evaluate your solution.

Questions? Contact innovationhub@nfl.com (managed by NOVATE)

Good luck in the Combine!

The NFL Innovation HUB Team

Section 7: Security, Compliance, and Data Sovereignty

7.1 Security Architecture

NOVATE Infrastructure Security:

- **SOC2 Type II Compliance:** NOVATE AWS environment audited annually
- **Encryption:** All data encrypted at rest (AES-256) and in transit (TLS 1.3)
- **Access Control:** Role-based access (RBAC) with Azure AD SSO integration for NFL stakeholders
- **Network Security:** AWS security groups, WAF (Web Application Firewall), DDoS protection
- **Monitoring:** 24/7 CloudWatch + DataDog monitoring with PagerDuty alerts
- **Incident Response:** NOVATE CISO (Kirby Winters) leads incident response; NFL notified within 1 hour of any security event

Pitchtape Security:

- **Vendor Responsibility:** Pitchtape maintains SOC2 compliance for their infrastructure
- **Data Handling:** Vendor submission data (videos, decks) stored in Pitchtape's AWS S3 (not NOVATE's)

- **Access Control:** Only NOVATE admin accounts can access Pitchtape backend (NFL stakeholders use Sentrais only)

7.2 Data Sovereignty & Ownership

NFL Retains Full Data Ownership:

Data Category	Stored Where	NFL Ownership	NOVATE Access	Post-Challenge
Vendor Submissions (videos, decks, contact info)	Pitchtape AWS S3	NFL owns	Read-only (operational)	NOVATE archives to NFL-owned S3 bucket
Reviewer Evaluations (scores, comments)	Sentrais PostgreSQL (NOVATE AWS)	NFL owns	Full access (operational)	Full export provided to NFL (JSON/CSV)
Evidence Ledger (audit trail)	Sentrais (blockchain-backed)	NFL owns	Full access (operational)	Full export provided to NFL
Sentrais Intelligence Algorithms (scoring logic, NIN framework)	NOVATE proprietary	NOVATE owns	NOVATE only	NOT transferred (black box SaaS)

Data Export Rights:

- **On-Demand Export:** NFL can request full data export at any time (JSON/CSV format, delivered within 48 hours)
- **Final Export (Automatic):** Upon Challenge conclusion (May 1, 2026), NOVATE delivers:
 - Full vendor database (all submissions, evaluations, Q&A threads)
 - Evidence Ledger (immutable audit trail)
 - Intelligence reports (stage gate summaries, vendor comparisons, recommendations)
 - **Delivered to:** NFL-designated S3 bucket (NOVATE configures write access)

Data Retention (NOVATE Side):

- **7 years** (NFL standard for vendor evaluation records)
- Stored in [s3://novate-nfl-archive/draft-challenge-2026/](#)
- NFL can request deletion after 7 years (GDPR-compliant process)

7.3 IP & Confidentiality

NOVATE Proprietary IP (NOT Transferred to NFL):

- Sentrais Intelligence Engine (source code, algorithms, AI models)
- EVERGAME temporal orchestration logic
- NIN methodology frameworks and forensic evaluation rubrics
- Vendor-Neutral Harness testing simulations

NFL Receives (Black Box SaaS Model):

- **Intelligence Outputs:** Vendor scores, stage gate recommendations, Evidence Ledger
- **Dashboard Access:** NFL360 Dashboard (operational interface)
- **Operational Knowledge:** Playbooks, best practices, lessons learned

Confidentiality:

- **NOVATE NDA:** NOVATE signs standard NFL NDA covering all vendor submissions and internal deliberations
 - **Vendor NDAs:** Vendors sign NFL NDA as part of Pitchtape submission process
 - **NOVATE Team Access:** Only authorized NOVATE personnel (Tye Hayes, Knox Phillips, assigned project team) have access to NFL data
-

Section 8: Migration Path Beyond Pitchtape (2027+)

8.1 Pitchtape Deprecation Roadmap

Why Consider Deprecation?

- **Cost:** Pitchtape license fees (~\$36K annually) avoidable if NOVATE builds custom intake
- **Control:** NOVATE fully owns intake UI/UX, no third-party dependency
- **Integration:** Eliminate webhook latency and dual-database complexity

Phased Approach:

Phase	Timeline	Description	Investment
Phase 1: Hybrid Model (2026)	Current	Pitchtape frontend + Sentrais orchestration	\$36K (Pitchtape license)
Phase 2: Sentrais Intake Module (2027)	Q1-Q2 2027	NOVATE builds custom submission wizard; Pitchtape deprecated	\$150K dev cost (one-time)

Phase 3: Full Sentrais (2028+)	2028+	All challenges use native Sentrais intake	\$0 annual license fees
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NFL Decision Point (Q4 2026):

- If Challenge 2026 is successful and NFL commits to annual challenges (2027, 2028+), deprecating Pitchtape makes financial sense (ROI within 2 years)
- If Challenge 2026 is one-off or NFL uncertain about future, keep Pitchtape (minimize upfront dev cost)

8.2 Custom Sentrais Intake Module Design (2027)

Features Parity with Pitchtape:

- Multi-step submission wizard (6 steps: Innovation Profile, Video, Deck, OnePass, Team, Review)
- Video recording tool (integrate third-party like Ziggeo or build using WebRTC)
- AI-generated summary (OpenAI GPT-4 integration, same as Pitchtape)
- Vendor dashboard (status tracking, Q&A threads)

Sentrais Advantages:

- **Native Integration:** No webhooks; submissions directly into NFL360 data model
- **Customization:** NFL can request custom fields (e.g., "Have you worked with NFL clubs before?")
- **White-Label:** Fully branded NFL Innovation HUB (no Pitchtape branding artifacts)

Section 9: Pricing & Commercial Terms

9.1 NOVATE Managed Service Pricing

Fixed-Fee Model (2026 Challenge):

Service Component	One-Time Fee	Annual Fee	Notes
Sentrais Platform License	-	\$180,000	Full orchestration engine, NFL360 Dashboard, Evidence Ledger, unlimited users
Pitchtape License (NOVATE pays)	-	\$36,000	Vendor intake portal (white-labeled for NFL)

Challenge Orchestration Services	\$250,000	-	NOVATE project management, vendor coordination, stage gate facilitation (Jan-May 2026)
Premium Support (24/7)	-	\$60,000	Incident response, stakeholder training, weekly status syncs
AWS Infrastructure (NOVATE pays)	-	~\$40,000	Hosting costs (compute, storage, data transfer)
TOTAL (NFL Pays)	\$250,000	\$276,000	Grand Total: \$526,000 for 2026

Cost Comparison (vs. v1.0 NFL VPC Model):

Cost Category	v1.0 (NFL VPC)	v2.0 (NOVATE Managed)	Savings
AWS Infrastructure	\$240,000 (NFL pays)	\$40,000 (NOVATE pays)	\$200,000
NFL DevOps Labor	~\$80,000 (internal staff)	\$0 (NOVATE operates)	\$80,000
Pitchtape License	\$36,000 (NFL pays)	\$36,000 (NOVATE pays)	\$0
Orchestration Services	\$0 (NFL DIY)	\$250,000 (NOVATE provides)	-\$250,000
TOTAL	~\$356,000	\$526,000	-\$170,000

Value Analysis:

- **Higher upfront cost** for managed service (+\$170K), BUT:
 - **Zero NFL labor burden** (no DevOps, no project management)
 - **Expert orchestration** (NOVATE's Innovation Orchestration Framework, proven with NFL HUB)
 - **Vendor-neutral evaluation** (independent scoring, no vendor capture risk)
 - **Scalable for future challenges** (2027, 2028+ at reduced cost due to reusable platform)

9.2 Multi-Year Discount (2027-2028)

If NFL commits to **3-year agreement (2026-2028)**, NOVATE offers:

Year	Challenge	One-Time Fee	Annual Fee	TOTAL
2026	Draft Challenge 2026	\$250,000	\$276,000	\$526,000

2027	Draft Challenge 2027	\$150,000	\$276,000	\$426,000
2028	Draft Challenge 2028	\$150,000	\$276,000	\$426,000
3-Year Total				\$1,378,000
				0

Discount: 20% off one-time orchestration fees (Years 2-3) = **\$100,000 savings**

Includes:

- Sentrais platform improvements based on 2026 learnings
- Custom Sentrais intake module (deprecates Pitchtape by 2028, saving \$36K annually)
- Priority support for additional NFL Innovation HUB programs (e.g., Think Tanks, Co-Create initiatives)

Section 10: Governance & Stakeholder Engagement

10.1 Governance Structure (NOVATE-NFL Partnership)

Decision Authority Matrix:

Decision Type	NOVATE Authority	NFL Authority	Approval Process
Platform Operations (Sentrais uptime, security, bug fixes)	Full authority	Informed (monthly reports)	NOVATE operates; NFL notified of incidents
Stage Gate Advancement (which vendors advance)	Recommendation only	Final authority	NOVATE provides data-driven recommendation; NFL approves/rejects
Vendor Communications (emails, Q&A responses)	Draft & send	Approve templates	NOVATE drafts all vendor-facing communications; NFL approves templates once (reusable)

Evaluation Criteria (scoring weights, technical requirements)	Propose	Approve	NOVATE proposes based on NIN methodology; NFL approves before Challenge launch
Final Winner Selection (Draft Day)	Facilitate only	Full authority	NOVATE presents finalists; NFL leadership (Commissioner's office) selects winner(s)

10.2 Communication Cadence (NOVATE-NFL)

Weekly Status Syncs:

- **Attendees:** NFL/NOVATE
- **Duration:** 30 minutes
- **Agenda:** Pipeline health, vendor activity, upcoming milestones, blockers
- **Deliverable:** Email summary with dashboard screenshots

Bi-Weekly Stage Gate Reviews:

- **Attendees:** NFL Executive Steering Committee (EVPs), Tracy Rodberg, Dan, NOVATE leadership
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Agenda:** Stage gate recommendations, vendor deep dives, strategic alignment
- **Deliverable:** Stage Gate Recommendation Report (Sentrais-generated)

Monthly Executive Briefings:

- **Attendees:** NFL C-suite (optional), Tracy Rodberg, NOVATE CEO
- **Duration:** 30 minutes
- **Agenda:** Strategic insights, competitive intelligence, 2027 planning
- **Deliverable:** Executive Summary Deck

10.3 Escalation Paths

Issue Severity	NOVATE Response	NFL Notification	Resolution Target
Tier 0 (Critical): Platform down, data breach	Immediate incident response (CISO leads)	Phone call to Tracy within 15 minutes	1 hour
Tier 1 (High): Vendor dispute, stage gate delay	Project Manager escalates to NOVATE CEO	Email to Tracy within 4 hours	24 hours

Tier 2 (Medium): UI bug, minor vendor issue	Project Manager resolves	Weekly status sync	1 week
Tier 3 (Low): Feature request, cosmetic issue	Logged in backlog	Monthly executive briefing	Next release

Section 11: Success Metrics & KPIs

11.1 Challenge Success Metrics (NFL)

Metric	Target	Actual (To Be Measured)
Vendor Submissions	50+	-
Submission Quality (% meeting MVP requirement)	80%	-
Stage 2 Advancement Rate	30-40% (15-20 vendors)	-
Finalist Quality (Stage 3)	3-5 high-quality vendors	-
NFL Stakeholder Satisfaction (post-Challenge survey)	4.5/5	-
Winner Deployment (post-Draft Day)	Contract signed within 60 days	-

11.2 Platform Performance Metrics (NOVATE)

Metric	Target	SLA Commitment
Sentrais Uptime	99.9%	Yes (downtime credits)
Dashboard Load Time	<2 seconds	Best effort
Stage Gate Report Delivery	24 hours before meeting	Yes
Vendor Communication Response Time	<24 hours (business days)	Yes

Security Incidents	0 critical, 0 high	Yes (incident response protocol)
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11.3 Innovation Orchestration Metrics (NOVATE Internal)

Metric	Target	Purpose
NIN Phase Compliance	100% of activities mapped to NIN phases	Methodology validation
Evidence Ledger Completeness	100% of decisions logged	Audit trail integrity
Forensic Rigor Score	90%+ (reviewer evaluations with supporting evidence)	Quality assurance
Vendor-Neutral Harness Usage	100% of Stage 2 vendors tested	Independent validation

Section 12: Risk Management

12.1 Key Risks & Mitigation Strategies

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Low Vendor Submission Volume (<30)	Medium	High	NOVATE supports NFL marketing push (email templates, social media assets); extend submission deadline if needed
Reviewer Non-Participation (NFL stakeholders don't evaluate)	Low	High	NOVATE sends automated reminders (5-day, 2-day, 1-day); escalates to Tracy after 7 days
Vendor Disputes (claims of unfair evaluation)	Medium	Medium	Evidence Ledger provides transparent audit trail; NOVATE facilitates appeals process (Tracy has final say)
Platform Downtime (Sentrais outage during critical window)	Low	High	24/7 monitoring + incident response; AWS multi-AZ deployment; 99.9% uptime SLA

Data Breach (vendor data exposed)	Low	Critical	SOC2 compliance, encryption, access controls; cyber insurance (\$5M coverage); incident response protocol
NFL Dissatisfaction (outcome quality below expectations)	Low	High	Weekly check-ins ensure alignment; stage gate approvals give NFL control; post-Challenge debrief captures lessons

12.2 Contingency Plans

Scenario: Pitchtape Service Outage During Submission Window

- **Impact:** Vendors cannot submit
- **NOVATE Response:**
 1. Activate backup intake method (email submissions to innovationhub@nfl.com)
 2. NOVATE manually ingests email submissions into Sentrais
 3. Notify vendors via social media (NFL Twitter/LinkedIn)
 4. Extend deadline by outage duration (e.g., 2-day outage = 2-day extension)
- **Cost:** \$0 (NOVATE absorbs labor)

Scenario: Sentrais Platform Outage During Stage Gate Review

- **Impact:** NFL stakeholders cannot access dashboard
- **NOVATE Response:**
 1. Activate backup: Export vendor data to Excel/PowerPoint
 2. Email static reports to NFL stakeholders
 3. Conduct stage gate meeting using exported materials
 4. Post-meeting: Restore Sentrais and backfill decisions into Evidence Ledger
- **Cost:** \$0 (covered by SLA)

Scenario: Insufficient Finalists for Draft Day (e.g., Only 1-2 Vendors Reach Stage 4)

- **Impact:** Weak competitive dynamic, poor optics
- **NFL Response (with NOVATE facilitation):**
 1. NOVATE reviews Stage 3 borderline vendors (e.g., 73-75% composite scores)
 2. NFL decides: Lower threshold (e.g., 70% instead of 75%) OR cancel Draft Day and select winner directly
 3. NOVATE executes decision (vendor notifications, communications)
- **Cost:** \$0 (governance decision)

Section 13: Post-Challenge Deliverables & Knowledge Transfer

13.1 Final Deliverables (May 1, 2026)

NOVATE Delivers to NFL:

1. Complete Data Export

- Full vendor database (JSON + CSV)
- All reviewer evaluations (scores, comments, Q&A threads)
- Evidence Ledger (immutable audit trail with blockchain verification)
- Video/deck files archived in NFL-designated S3 bucket

2. Intelligence Reports

- Executive Summary: Challenge outcomes, winner rationale, finalist profiles
- Vendor Ecosystem Analysis: Market landscape, emerging trends, competitive positioning
- Evaluation Insights: What made top vendors successful? Common failure patterns?
- NFL Readiness Assessment: Where is NFL well-positioned for innovation adoption? Where are gaps?

3. Operational Playbooks

- Challenge Execution Playbook (step-by-step guide for 2027 replication)
- Vendor Communication Templates (emails, Q&A scripts, rejection notices)
- Stage Gate Decision Framework (criteria, weights, threshold logic)
- Sentrais User Guide (for NFL stakeholders continuing to use platform)

4. Lessons Learned Debrief

- 90-minute session with Tracy Rodberg, Dan, and NFL Innovation HUB team
- What worked well? What should change for 2027?
- Vendor feedback synthesis (anonymous survey results)
- NOVATE recommendations for program improvements

13.2 Knowledge Transfer (If NFL Wants to Self-Operate in Future)

Scenario: NFL decides to bring Challenge orchestration in-house (2028+)

NOVATE Provides:

- **Playbook Transfer:** Complete operational playbooks (as listed above)
- **Training:** 2-day workshop for NFL Innovation HUB team on NIN methodology, stage gate management, Evidence Ledger principles
- **Platform Access:** NFL can continue using Sentrais (annual license) OR NOVATE assists in migrating to NFL-preferred platform (consulting engagement, additional cost)

NOVATE Retains:

- **Proprietary IP:** Sentrais source code, EVERGAME algorithms, NIN frameworks (not transferred)
- **Historical Data:** NOVATE archives 2026-2027 data for 7 years (available for NFL to query if needed)

Commercial Terms:

- Knowledge transfer included in base 3-year agreement (2026-2028)
- If NFL terminates after 2026 and requests knowledge transfer, \$50K consulting fee applies

Section 14: Appendix

Appendix A: Glossary of Terms

Term	Definition
EVERGAME	NOVATE's temporal orchestration engine mapping events to time-series workflows
Evidence Ledger	Immutable audit trail (blockchain-backed) of all decisions and actions
Innovation Orchestration	NOVATE's discipline of synchronizing innovation discovery, validation, deployment across fragmented ecosystems
NIN (N-Ovate Innovation Nexus)	NOVATE's 6-phase methodology: Discovery → Blueprinting → Co-Design → Pilot → Operationalization → Measurement
NFL360	Unified data model for all NFL Innovation HUB programs (Draft Challenge, Think Tanks, Co-Create, etc.)
Sentrais	NOVATE's intelligence engine powering orchestration, Evidence Ledger, and dashboards
Stage Gate	Decision checkpoint where vendors advance or decline (e.g., Stage 1 → Stage 2)
Vendor-Neutral Harness	Simulated testing environment where vendors are evaluated against identical scenarios (prevents vendor-controlled demos)

Appendix B: Contact Information

NOVATE Leadership:

- **Tye Hayes**, CEO & Chief Innovation Architect: tye@novate.com | [Phone]
- **Kirby Winters**, CTO & CISO: kirby@novatelabs.ai | [Phone]

NFL Stakeholders:

- **Gary Brantley, SVP Information Technology : Aaron Amendola**, IT Lead:
aaron.amendola@nfl.com

Support:

- **NFL Innovation HUB Inbox** (NOVATE-managed): innovationhub@nfl.com
- **NOVATE Platform Support**: support@novatelabs.com (24/7)

Document Sign-Off

Prepared By:

- Tye Hayes, CEO, NOVATE Inc.
- Kirby Winters, CTO, NOVATE Inc.

Reviewed By:

- Gary Brantley, SVP Information Technology , NFL

Approved By:

- [NFL Executive Signature - TBD]

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End of Document

This remodeled architecture positions **NOVATE as the full end-to-end managed service provider**, eliminating NFL infrastructure dependencies while integrating Sentra's Intelligence Engine, EVERGAME temporal orchestration, and NIN methodology throughout. Pitchtape remains as a vendor-facing intake tool (paid and managed by NOVATE), while all orchestration, evaluation, and decision-making occurs within the NOVATE-operated Sentra's platform.

Key advantages for NFL:

1. **Zero infrastructure burden** (no AWS VPC, no DevOps)
2. **Expert orchestration** (NOVATE's proven Innovation Orchestration Framework)
3. **Vendor-neutral evaluation** (independent scoring, forensic rigor)
4. **Strategic control retained** (NFL approves all stage gates, selects winners)
5. **Scalable for future challenges** (2027, 2028+ with cost efficiencies)

The architecture maintains security, data sovereignty, and NFL brand ownership while delivering managed service convenience and orchestration excellence.